

THE SILENCE

When the world goes quiet...
don't answer.

STORY
BOOK



THE SILENT
HOUR
DO NOT
SPEAK

BY
MUBITA SIASABUZINGO KABIKA

THE SILENCE

A Mystery and Suspense Novel

By

Mubita Siasabuzingo Kabika

"Some doors are locked to keep danger out..."

Others are locked to keep something in."

First Edition

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THE SILENCE

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CHAPTER ONE

WHEN THE BELL RANG

If you asked the people of Chisanga what frightened them most, none of them would answer immediately.

They would first look over their shoulders.

Then towards the hills.

Then to the forest.

Only after convincing themselves that nobody was listening would they lower their voices.

"It is not what lives in the forest that we fear."

A pause would follow.

"It is what comes out when the forest becomes silent."

For more than a hundred years, no stranger had ever understood those words.

Some laughed.

Some dismissed them as the superstitions of old villagers who feared the dark.

None of those strangers stayed long enough to discover why every house in Chisanga was built with heavy wooden doors... why every window had thick woven curtains... or why, every evening before nine o'clock, the entire village disappeared indoors as though the earth itself had swallowed its people.

No one asked questions after sunset.

Not if they wished to see another sunrise.

The village rested quietly at the foot of the Namwala Hills, where the plains stretched endlessly towards

the horizon and ancient trees stood like silent guardians over generations of forgotten stories.

Morning in Chisanga always arrived gently.

Before dawn had fully broken, the distant crowing of roosters echoed between the hills. Smoke curled lazily from grass thatched kitchens as women prepared breakfast over charcoal braziers. The smell of roasting maize and boiling tea drifted through the crisp July air.

Children hurried along dusty footpaths wearing faded school uniforms, laughing as they challenged one another to races.

Old men sat beneath the great musuku tree in the centre of the village, discussing politics, harvests, football and

memories that grew taller every time they were told.

Everything appeared wonderfully ordinary.

That was Chisanga's greatest deception.

It looked like every other peaceful village in Zambia.

Only those who lived there knew that every ordinary day ended in exactly the same extraordinary way.

Before darkness settled...

Silence was prepared.

Sixteen year old Mubanga Siame was unlike most boys his age.

While others accepted village traditions without question, Mubanga wanted explanations.

He wanted reasons.

He believed every mystery had an answer waiting to be discovered.

His grandmother often said curiosity was both a blessing and a curse.

"You ask too many questions," she would tell him.

"One day, one of them will ask you a question in return."

He never understood what she meant.

That morning, Mubanga walked towards the fields carrying a hoe across his shoulder. The rising sun painted the maize golden while dew clung to every blade of grass like tiny crystals.

He stopped near a stream where several women were filling clay pots with water.

"Good morning, Ba Nalubilo," he greeted one elderly woman.

She smiled warmly.

"Morning, my son. Tell your grandmother I'll visit after church."

"I will."

As Mubanga turned to leave, he overheard two younger women whispering.

"...they found it again."

"Where?"

"Near the western forest."

"Did the headman see it?"

A brief silence followed.

"He burned it before sunrise."

The women noticed Mubanga looking towards them.

Instantly, their conversation ended.

One of them forced a smile.

"You'll be late for the fields."

Mubanga nodded politely.

But the question remained.

Found what?

Why burn it?

And why before sunrise?

Questions.

Always questions.

Never answers.

By midday, the warmth of the sun had driven most villagers beneath the shade of enormous trees.

Mubanga worked beside his friend, Chola, repairing a damaged fence around one of the maize fields.

"You think too much," Chola laughed, pushing another wooden post into the ground.

"You don't think enough."

"I sleep peacefully."

"So do goats."

Chola burst into laughter.

"You'll end up like Ba Muweemba."

"The old storyteller?"

"The one who sees mysteries everywhere."

"I like his stories."

"Stories are meant for children."

"No," Mubanga replied quietly.

"Stories survive because somebody once lived them."

For a moment, neither spoke.

A gentle wind crossed the fields.

Then Chola's smile faded.

"Don't say things like that."

"Like what?"

"About stories being true."

"Why not?"

Chola looked towards the western horizon.

Beyond the maize fields...

Beyond the grazing cattle...

Beyond the scattered acacia trees...

The forest waited.

Dark.

Still.

Ancient.

Even from several kilometres away, it seemed strangely different from every other woodland surrounding the village.

Its trees stood impossibly close together.

Their branches twisted into shapes that looked almost

human beneath the afternoon sun.

Mubanga noticed his friend's expression.

"You've been listening to your grandmother again."

"My grandmother doesn't joke about that place."

"Neither does mine."

"Exactly."

Chola drove another post into the ground.

"My grandfather always said there are two forests."

Mubanga smiled.

"There is only one."

"No."

Chola shook his head.

"One belongs to people."

"And the other?"

"The other belongs to whatever comes after the bell."

Before Mubanga could answer, both boys heard someone shouting from the village.

"The headman is calling everyone!"

Workers across the fields straightened immediately.

Something serious had happened.

The two boys exchanged puzzled glances before hurrying back towards Chisanga, unaware that before the day ended, Mubanga would hear a voice that should have been impossible...

A voice belonging to someone who had died ten years earlier.

The news spread through Chisanga faster than a bushfire carried by the dry July wind.

Men abandoned their hoes in the fields.

Women covered their cooking pots and hurried from their kitchens.

Children who had been playing beneath the musuku tree were called home by anxious mothers.

Within minutes, nearly every villager had gathered beneath the enormous tree at the centre of Chisanga.

Its thick branches stretched across the open ground like the arms of an old guardian, providing shade to generations who had lived and died beneath it.

Hanging from one of its strongest limbs was the village's ancient brass bell.

Its weathered surface had darkened with age, yet it remained polished around the rim, as though countless hands had touched it over the years.

Mubanga had always found that strange.

Nobody ever rang the bell except the headman.

Yet somehow, it never gathered dust.

Headman Paul Muwaanga stood quietly before the crowd. Although he was nearly seventy years old, his broad shoulders and commanding voice still earned instant respect.

He waited until everyone had arrived.

No one spoke.

Even the children sensed that this was no ordinary meeting.

Finally, the headman lifted his walking stick.

"My people," he began, his deep voice carrying across the gathering, "last night, someone entered the western forest."

A wave of murmurs swept through the crowd.

Several elderly women immediately covered their mouths.

One old man slowly removed his hat and lowered his head.

Mubanga noticed the fear in their faces.

Real fear.

Not the kind born from stories.

The kind born from memory.

The headman raised his hand, and silence returned.

*"The footprints were found
this morning."*

*Again, whispers rippled
through the crowd.*

"They led into the forest..."

He paused.

"...but none came back."

*The murmuring stopped
instantly.*

Mubanga frowned.

*How could footprints
simply disappear?*

Unless...

No.

*There had to be an
explanation.*

The headman continued.

*"We do not know who
entered."*

"We do not know why."

*"But from today
onwards..."*

His voice hardened.

*"No one is to go near the
western forest after
midday."*

*Several villagers nodded
immediately.*

*Others quietly whispered
prayers.*

*Only Mubanga remained
unconvinced.*

*People disappeared every
year across the country.
Sometimes they became lost.
Sometimes they left without
telling anyone.*

*Why should this be
different?*

*As the meeting ended,
groups of villagers slowly
drifted away, speaking in
hushed voices.*

*Mubanga noticed Ba
Muweemba sitting alone
beneath the far side of the
musuku tree.*

The old storyteller stared at the bell as though expecting it to speak.

Mubanga walked over.

"You don't believe someone simply got lost, do you?"

Ba Mweemba smiled faintly.

"I stopped believing in simple things many years ago."

"You've lived here all your life."

"I have."

"Then tell me."

The old man looked directly into Mubanga's eyes.

"What do you want to know?"

"The truth."

A long silence followed.

Finally, Ba Mweemba sighed.

"When I was your age..."

His weathered hands tightened around his walking stick.

"...there were twelve of us."

"Twelve?"

"My friends."

"What happened?"

The old man's eyes drifted towards the forest.

"We thought courage meant proving old people wrong."

Mubanga leaned closer.

"So we entered the forest after sunset."

His heart quickened.

"And?"

"Only five of us returned."

The words struck Mubanga like a stone.

"What happened to the others?"

Ba Mweemba's face grew pale.

"I wish I knew."

"You never found them?"

The old man slowly shook his head.

"We searched for weeks."

"Nothing?"

"Nothing."

"No bodies?"

"No."

"No footprints?"

"No."

"No blood?"

"No."

"It was as if..."

His voice almost disappeared.

"...the forest had swallowed them."

Mubanga wanted to ask another question, but the old man suddenly grabbed his wrist.

His grip was surprisingly strong.

"Listen carefully."

"I'm listening."

"There are three rules every child in Chisanga is taught."

Mubanga nodded.

"The first..."

"Never enter the western forest after sunset."

"The second..."

"Never answer a voice that calls your name from the darkness."

A chill crept across Mubanga's skin.

"And the third?"

For several seconds, Ba Muweemba remained silent.

His eyes slowly lifted towards the brass bell hanging above them.

"When the bell rings..."

His voice became barely more than a whisper.

"...make sure you are already home."

Just then...

The wind stopped.

Completely.

Leaves that had been dancing in the breeze froze motionless.

The chickens wandering through the village suddenly scattered beneath nearby houses.

Dogs tucked their tails between their legs and whimpered.

Even the cattle grazing nearby lifted their heads at the same moment.

Mubanga had never seen animals behave like that before.

Ba Muweemba looked toward the western forest.

His face drained of colour.

"It has begun."

"What has?"

The old man didn't answer.

Instead, he slowly stood up and began walking towards his house much faster than anyone would expect for a man his age.

Around them, the entire village sprang into motion.

Women rushed to collect children.

Men hurried to secure livestock.

Doors slammed shut one after another.

It was still only late afternoon.

Yet Chisanga was already preparing for night.

Mubanga stood alone beneath the musuku tree, watching the fear spread through the village like an unseen disease.

For the first time in his life...

He realised everyone in Chisanga shared a secret.

Everyone...

Except him.

The sun drifted slowly toward the western horizon, bathing Chisanga in a warm golden light. Normally, this was Mubanga's favourite time of day. The heat softened, children played one last game before supper, and the smell of

firewood smoke filled the air.

Today, the village felt different.

The laughter had disappeared.

Women called their children indoors much earlier than usual.

Even the men who usually remained beneath the musuku tree until dusk quietly made their way home.

Mubanga stood outside his grandmother's house, watching the unusual scene unfold.

"Something has frightened everyone," he murmured.

"You have noticed."

Nalumango's voice came from behind him.

She was carrying a small clay pot of water, her face unusually serious.

Mubanga turned.

"Grandmother... what happened here years ago?"

She froze.

The pot in her hands trembled slightly.

"Who told you to ask that?"

"No one."

She searched his face, as though trying to decide whether he was telling the truth.

"You spoke to Ba Mweemba."

"I did."

"And what did he tell you?"

"He said seven boys disappeared."

Nalumango closed her eyes.

For several moments, she said nothing.

Then she slowly sat on the wooden stool outside the house.

"I was younger than you are now," she began quietly.

"I remember the day their mothers stopped waiting."

Mubanga sat beside her.

"The entire village searched for them."

"For how long?"

"Twenty three days."

"No one found anything?"

She shook her head.

"Not a shirt."

"Not a shoe."

"Not even a footprint."

The silence between them grew heavy.

Finally, Mubanga asked the question that had lived in his heart since childhood.

"Grandmother..."

She looked at him.

"Why does everyone fear the bell?"

Nalumango stared toward the musuku tree in the centre of the village.

"When that bell rings..."

she whispered,

"it is not warning us."

Mubanga frowned.

"Then what is it doing?"

"It is telling us..."

She stopped.

Her breathing became uneven.

"No."

"I've already said too much."

She stood abruptly and walked into the house.

Mubanga remained outside, frustrated.

Every answer seemed to create even more questions.

As darkness slowly approached, he noticed something unusual.

An old woman named Ba Cheelo Joseph was walking from house to house.

At each doorway, she sprinkled a fine white powder across the entrance before whispering a prayer.

"What is she doing?" Mubanga asked.

Nalumango returned carrying a woven basket.

"Protecting her neighbours."

"From what?"

She looked directly at him.

*"From whatever walks
after the bell."*

*Mubanga almost laughed.
Almost.*

But something stopped him.

*It wasn't what she had
said.*

*It was the expression on her
face.*

She believed every word.

*Just before sunset, another
strange thing happened.*

*A flock of weaver birds
suddenly burst from the
western forest.*

Hundreds of them.

*They flew low over the
rooftops without making a
single sound.*

*Mubanga watched in
amazement.*

*"I've never seen birds fly
silently."*

*"You were not supposed
to."*

*Nalumanga quickly pulled
him inside.*

She closed the wooden door.

*Then she slid a thick iron
bolt into place.*

*One by one, she covered
every window with heavy
woven mats.*

The house grew darker.

*Only the small flame of a
kerosene lamp remained.*

"Grandmother..."

"Not now."

*She opened a wooden chest
and removed an old Bible.*

*Its leather cover was badly
worn.*

*Several loose pages had
yellowed with age.*

*She placed it carefully on
the table.*

Beside it, she set an old family photograph.

Mubanga picked it up.

He recognised his father immediately.

Standing beside him was his mother, smiling brightly.

But there was someone else in the picture.

A man Mubanga had never seen before.

"Who is this?"

Nalumango quickly took the photograph from his hands.

"You've never asked about him."

"I've never noticed him."

She gently brushed dust from the frame.

"His name was Sitali."

"My uncle?"

She nodded.

"What happened to him?"

The room fell silent.

Nalumango's eyes filled with tears.

"He disappeared."

Mubanga felt a chill.

"When?"

She looked toward the closed door.

"On the night..."

"The bell rang by itself."

Before Mubanga could ask another question...

Dong...

The ancient brass bell echoed across Chisanga.

Once.

The sound rolled through the hills like distant thunder.

*Every dog in the village
stopped barking.*

The wind disappeared.

*The kerosene lamp
flickered.*

*Nalumango immediately
stood.*

*Without speaking, she
extinguished the flame.*

*Darkness swallowed the
room.*

*Only pale moonlight
slipped through tiny gaps
in the woven mats covering
the windows.*

Dong...

The bell rang a second time.

*Mubanga's heartbeat
quickened.*

*He had heard the bell every
evening since childhood.*

But tonight...

For the first time...

He was afraid.

Then came the third ring.

Dong...

Silence.

Not ordinary silence.

Absolute silence.

No insects.

No wind.

No cattle.

No footsteps.

*It was as though the entire
world had stopped
breathing.*

*Mubanga could hear only
the pounding of his own
heart.*

*He looked toward his
grandmother.*

She had closed her eyes.

*Her lips moved silently in
prayer.*

Then...

From somewhere outside...

A voice drifted through the darkness.

Soft.

Clear.

Familiar.

"Mubanga..."

His blood ran cold.

He knew that voice.

It belonged to his father.

The same father who had died ten years earlier.

Mubanga's heart hammered against his chest.

He stared at the wooden door, unable to move.

The voice had been unmistakable.

Not similar.

Not familiar.

It had been his father's voice exactly as he remembered it, calm, gentle, and warm.

The same voice that had sung to him when he was a child.

The same voice he had not heard since the day of the accident.

He swallowed hard.

"Grandmother..."

Nalumanga's eyes flew open.

Before he could say another word, she pressed a trembling finger against her lips.

"Do not speak."

Her whisper was so faint it was almost inaudible.

The room fell silent once more.

Then...

"Mubanga..."

The voice came again.

This time it sounded closer.

As though whoever was calling him had walked across the yard and was now standing just beyond the front door.

Mubanga instinctively took a step forward.

Nalumanga seized his wrist.

Her grip was surprisingly firm.

"No."

"But , "

"I said no."

"It sounds like Father."

"I know whose voice it sounds like."

"Then maybe..."

"There is no maybe."

She lowered her voice even further.

"Your father was buried ten years ago."

A shiver crept down Mubanga's spine.

Outside, the voice called again.

"My son..."

The words pierced his heart.

His father had always called him that.

No one else in the village ever had.

Tears gathered in Mubanga's eyes.

For one impossible moment, hope overwhelmed reason.

Could his father somehow be alive?

Had everyone been mistaken?

His feet carried him toward the door before he realized what he was doing.

Nalumango stepped in front of him.

"If you open that door..."

Her voice broke.

"...you will not come back."

The words froze him.

He had never seen his grandmother so frightened.

Never.

Outside, silence returned.

Several long minutes passed.

Neither of them moved.

Neither of them spoke.

The old wall clock ticked softly.

Tick.

Tick.

Tick.

Then...

Three slow knocks echoed through the house.

Knock.

...

Knock.

...

Knock.

Not loud.

Not violent.

Patient.

Almost polite.

Mubanga felt every hair on his arms stand upright.

Someone...

Or something...

Was standing on the other side of the door.

Another knock followed.

This time accompanied by a quiet voice.

"Nalumango..."

Mubanga looked at his grandmother.

Her face had turned pale.

It was no longer his father's voice.

It was his grandfather's.

The husband she had buried more than twenty years earlier.

Fears rolled silently down her cheeks.

She closed her eyes tightly.

"Oh God..."

she whispered.

"It knows."

Mubanga frowned.

"What knows?"

She didn't answer.

The knocking stopped.

A heavy silence settled over the house once again.

Minutes passed.

Then, from outside, came the sound of slow footsteps.

Crunch...

Crunch...

Crunch...

As though someone was walking around the house, one careful step at a time.

The footsteps paused beneath the bedroom window.

Neither Mubanga nor Nalumango dared breathe.

Then they moved again.

Around the back of the house.

Past the kitchen.

Toward the small goat shelter.

Another pause.

Mubanga imagined someone standing there, listening.

Waiting.

Testing every door and every window.

The footsteps resumed.

They circled the house once more.

This time they stopped directly outside the front entrance.

Nothing happened.

Not for what felt like an eternity.

Finally...

The footsteps began moving away.

Slowly.

Deliberately.

Crunch...

Crunch...

Crunch...

Until they disappeared into the distance.

Only then did Nalumango allow herself to breathe.

She sank onto a wooden chair, exhausted.

Mubanga remained standing.

His legs felt weak.

His mind raced with questions.

"What was that?"

Nalumango wiped away her tears.

"I have prayed that you would never hear those voices."

"What are they?"

She looked into the darkness.

"My son..."

she said quietly,

"There are some things that do not hunt your body."

"They hunt your hope."

Mubanga did not understand.

"But why would it use Father's voice?"

"Because it knows that grief opens doors no key ever could."

Those words lingered in the darkness.

Neither of them spoke again.

Outside...

The Silent Hour continued.

And somewhere beyond the last houses of Chisanga...

Deep inside the ancient forest...

A pair of unseen eyes watched the village.

Waiting.

Patiently.

As though they had all the time in the world.

The night seemed endless.

Mubanga did not sleep.

Every time he closed his eyes, he heard his father's voice calling his name. He could still picture the door only a few steps away, wondering what would have happened had he opened it.

Would he have found his father?

Or something pretending to be him?

The question haunted him until the first faint cry of a rooster broke the silence.

Nalumango slowly lifted her head.

"It's over."

Mubanga frowned.

"How do you know?"

"The roosters only crow when it leaves."

She stood, stretched her stiff legs and walked toward the front door.

Before touching the bolt, she whispered a short prayer.

Only then did she slide it open.

The cool morning air drifted into the house.

Sunlight spilled across the floor.

Everything appeared normal.

Too normal.

Mubanga stepped outside.

The village was slowly coming back to life.

Women swept their yards.

Children chased chickens.

Men greeted one another as though nothing unusual had happened during the night.

Yet their smiles looked forced.

Their eyes carried the weariness of people who had survived something they never spoke about.

Mubanga looked down.

His breath caught.

Fresh footprints surrounded the house.

Bare footprints.

Large enough to belong to an adult.

They formed a perfect circle around the building.

One after another.

*Every single footprint
pointed toward the house.*

Not one faced away.

*He followed them
carefully.*

*The circle continued around
the kitchen.*

Past the water drum.

Behind the goat shelter.

Around the mango tree.

Then...

*They ended exactly where
they had begun.*

*Mubanga looked beyond
them.*

*There were no approaching
footprints.*

No departing footprints.

Only the circle.

It was impossible.

"Nalumango!"

She hurried outside.

*The moment she saw the
footprints, her face turned
pale.*

*Without saying a word, she
knelt and touched one gently
with her fingertips.*

Her lips trembled.

*"It came closer than
before."*

"What is it?"

She stood immediately.

*"Go and fetch Headman
Paul Mwaanga."*

"What?"

"Now."

"But , "

"Do not ask questions."

*Her voice was unusually
firm.*

"Run."

Mubanga sprinted through the village.

As he passed each house, he noticed people staring at him.

Some looked frightened.

Others quickly looked away.

Word travelled quickly in Chisanga.

By the time he reached the headman's home, it seemed everyone already knew something had happened.

Paul Mwaanga was standing outside, speaking quietly with Ba Muemba.

Both men turned as Mubanga approached.

The headman studied his face.

"It visited your home."

Mubanga stopped.

"You already know?"

Paul Mwaanga gave a slow nod.

"I knew before you arrived."

"How?"

The old man looked toward the sky.

"Because last night..."

He paused.

"...the bell rang four times."

Mubanga frowned.

"That's impossible."

"The bell always rings three."

"It has."

The headman's voice was heavy.

"For seventy one years."

"Until last night."

Ba Muweemba removed his hat.

"I prayed I would never live to hear a fourth bell."

Mubanga felt his stomach tighten.

"What does a fourth bell mean?"

Neither elder answered immediately.

Instead, they exchanged uneasy glances.

Finally, Ba Muweemba spoke.

"It means..."

His voice cracked.

"...the Silence has chosen someone."

The words lingered in the cool morning air.

Mubanga stared at them, confused.

"Chosen for what?"

Before anyone could answer, a desperate scream echoed from the far end of the village.

It was a woman's voice.

Raw.

Broken.

Filled with terror.

Villagers rushed from every direction.

Mubanga, the headman and Ba Muweemba ran toward the sound.

The scream came from the home of Ba Cheelo Joseph, the elderly woman who had gone from house to house the previous evening, sprinkling white powder at every doorway.

She was standing in her yard, shaking uncontrollably.

*Her hands pointed toward
the open door of her house.*

"My son..."

she cried.

"My son is gone!"

People hurried inside.

*Moments later, they
emerged one by one.*

Silent.

*The sleeping mat was still
there.*

*His blanket lay neatly
folded.*

*His shoes remained beside
the bed.*

*His clothes hung on the
wall.*

Nothing had been stolen.

Nothing was broken.

*But Ba Joseph Cheelo's
twenty year old son,
Luyando...*

Had vanished.

*Without opening the locked
door.*

Without leaving a window.

Without making a sound.

*Without leaving a single
footprint.*

The villagers stood frozen.

*No one dared speak the
words that filled every
mind.*

The Silence had returned.

Epilogue

The Truth Behind the Silence

The disappearance of Luyando changed Chisanga forever.

For weeks, the villagers searched every path, every stream, every anthill, and every corner of the western forest. Hunters from neighbouring villages joined the search. Even the police came, but they found nothing.

No footprints.

No torn clothing.

No signs of a struggle.

It was as though Luyando had simply vanished from the face of the earth.

Mubanga refused to accept that the mystery would never be solved.

With the help of Ba Muweemba and Headman Paul Mwaanga, he returned to the western forest one final time. Deep inside, beyond a circle of ancient mukuwa trees, they discovered the ruins of an old settlement that no one in the village had spoken about for generations.

At its centre stood another bell.

Unlike the one in Chisanga, this bell was cracked down the middle.

Ba Muweemba fell to his knees.

"This is where it began," he whispered.

Many years earlier, a prosperous village had

occupied that place. One season, greed divided its people. Brothers stole from brothers. Friends betrayed one another. The village elders ignored justice, and innocent people suffered while the guilty grew rich.

According to the oldest records hidden in the headman's house, the final elder had spoken these words before dying:

"When truth is silenced, silence itself will judge those who forget."

Soon afterwards, the village was abandoned.

Only the bell remained.

For generations, the people of Chisanga honoured one rule: when the bell rang each night, everyone remained indoors in silence, not because silence was evil, but because it reminded them

to live honestly, respect one another, and never repeat the sins that had destroyed the first village.

As time passed, the reason behind the tradition was forgotten, but the ritual remained.

Then Mubanga noticed fresh footprints leading behind the ruined bell.

He followed them into a small cave hidden beneath tangled roots.

Inside lay Luyando.

Weak.

Hungry.

Alive.

He had become trapped after the cave entrance collapsed during the night. Unable to escape, he had survived by drinking water that seeped through the rocks.

His cries had never reached the village.

The mystery that had terrified everyone had, in this case, a human explanation.

Luyando was rescued and returned home, where his mother embraced him through tears of joy.

News spread quickly.

The villagers celebrated, but Mubanga's thoughts remained with the ruined bell.

As everyone prepared to leave, he looked back one last time.

The cracked bell...

Was gently swaying.

There was no wind.

No one stood near it.

Yet it moved.

A faint sound echoed through the forest.

Dong...

Just once.

Ba Mweemba slowly removed his hat.

Without saying a word, the three men turned and began the long walk home.

None of them spoke about what they had heard.

Years later, Mubanga became the new headman of Chisanga.

He taught every child the true meaning of the Silent Hour.

"It is not fear that protects us," he would say.

"It is wisdom."

"But remember this..."

He would pause and glance toward the western forest.

"Some mysteries are never meant to be solved completely."

Every evening, as the sun disappeared behind the hills, the old brass bell continued to ring three times.

The villagers still closed their doors.

They still sat quietly with their families.

Not because they knew what waited in the darkness...

But because they respected what they did not understand.

And on some nights, when the wind was perfectly still, those who listened carefully claimed they could hear footsteps far beyond the forest.

Always approaching.

Never arriving.

The End.

Dedication

To my family,
who taught me that stories carry both memory and
meaning.

And to every reader who has ever been curious
enough to ask,
“What lies beyond the silence?”

SILENCE HAS A HISTORY. THE TRUTH HAS A VOICE.

In the quiet village of Chisanga, life ends every day at exactly nine o'clock.

When the ancient brass bell rings, every door is locked, every window is covered, and every voice falls silent. For generations, this rule has never been broken.

Until the night Mubanga hears a voice calling his name from the darkness... a voice that should not exist.

As mysterious disappearances begin to shake the village, Mubanga is drawn into a truth buried deeper than fear itself. The deeper he searches, the more he realizes that some traditions are not meant to protect the living... but to keep something else contained.

THE SILENCE is a gripping Zambian suspense novel that blends folklore, mystery, and psychological tension into a haunting story of curiosity, courage, and the unknown.

*Because in Chisanga...
silence is not peace.
It is a warning.*



MUBITA SIASABUZINGO KABIKA

A Zambian storyteller with a passion for culture, community, and creativity.

His work is inspired by the people, traditions, and rhythms of Zambia—and the belief that every story can uplift, educate, and unite.



Proudly Zambian.
Inspired by our land.
Dedicated to our people.



A TRIBUTE TO OUR SOUND

From the storytelling roots of Chisanga to the timeless music of legends like Mr. Fortune, Zambia's soul lives in our stories, our songs, and our spirit.

THE SILENCE IS OUR STORY.

Mubita

For Zambia. Forever.



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